

THE FURNACE

Fornax



SIZE RANKING 41

BRIGHTEST STAR Alpha (α) 3.9

GENITIVE Fornacis

ABBREVIATION For

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM November–December

FULLY VISIBLE 50°N–90°S



A handful of faint stars makes up this undistinguished constellation of the southern sky. Fornax is situated on the edge of Eridanus and Cetus, and it represents a furnace used by

chemists for distillation. It was originally known by the name Fornax Chemica, the chemical furnace, but this has since been shortened to Fornax.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

The brightest star in the constellation, 4th-magnitude Alpha (α) Fornacis, has a yellow companion, which orbits it every 300 years. This 7th-magnitude star is visible through a small telescope.

On the border of Fornax with Eridanus lies a small cluster of galaxies known as the Fornax Cluster (see p.329). It is about 65 million light-years away, and its brightest member—the peculiar spiral NGC 1316—is a radio source known as Fornax A. Another prominent member of the Fornax Cluster is the beautiful barred spiral galaxy NGC 1365.

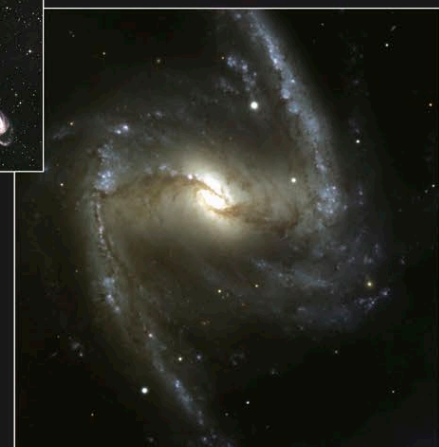


THE FURNACE CLUSTER

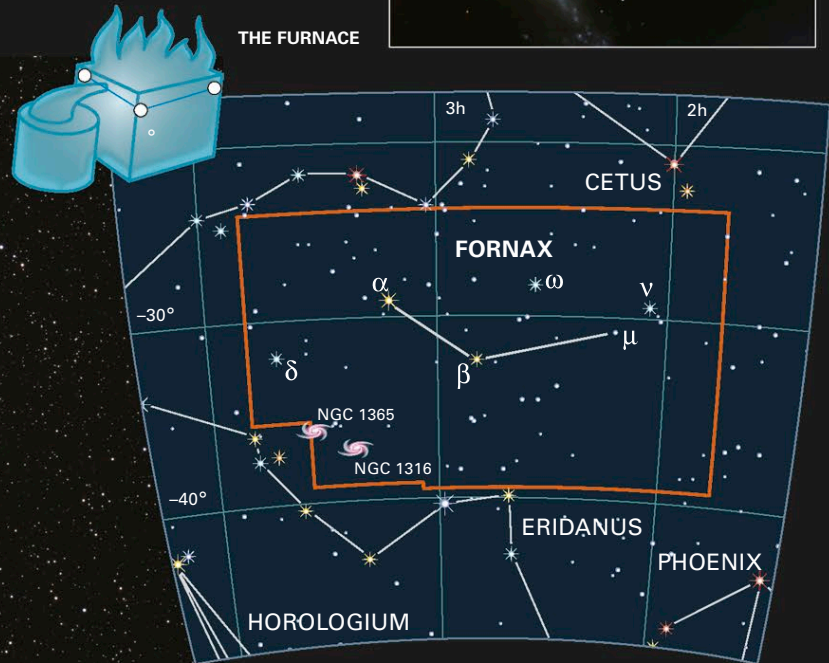
Most of the galaxies in this cluster in southern Fornax are ellipticals, including the 10th-magnitude NGC 1399 (left of center in this photograph). Standing out among the elliptical galaxies is the large barred spiral NGC 1365 (bottom right).

NGC 1365

This barred spiral galaxy is the largest in the Fornax Cluster and is about as massive as the Milky Way. It can be identified through a moderate-sized telescope.



THE FURNACE



PROTECTED POSITION

Fornax is tucked into a bend in the celestial river, Eridanus. It was introduced by Nicolas Louis de Lacaille during the 18th century.

THE CHISEL

Caelum



SIZE RANKING 81

BRIGHTEST STAR Alpha (α) 4.4

ABBREVIATION Cae

GENITIVE Caeli

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM December–January

FULLY VISIBLE 41°N–90°S

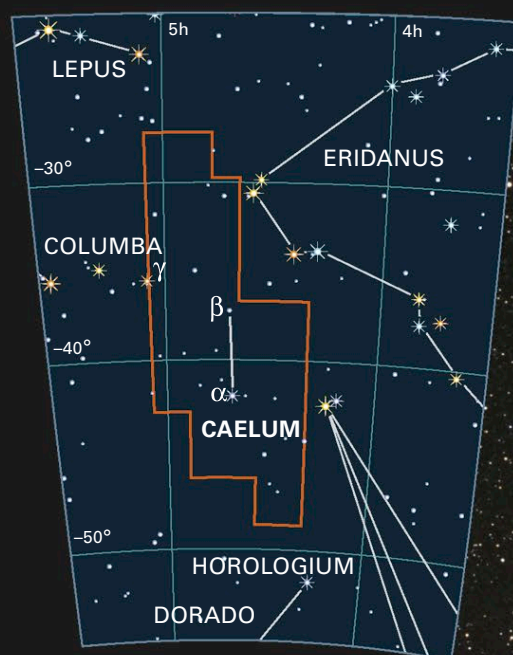


Sandwiched between Eridanus and Columba is this small and faint southern constellation, which was introduced in the 18th century by the French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille (see p.422). It represents a stonemason's chisel.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Gamma (γ) Caeli is a double star, consisting of an orange giant of magnitude 4.6, with an

8th-magnitude companion. Because they are positioned close together, a modest-sized telescope is required in order to separate them.



THE CHISEL



ENGRAVED IN STONE

Beta (β) and Alpha (α) Caeli mark the shaft of the celestial chisel, which points toward the constellations Dorado and Reticulum in the south.